



RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Nelson Tasman

Whakatū

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Nelson Tasman.

Ethicare Resourcing

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Nau mai ki Whakatū

Welcome to Nelson Tasman

Moving country is a bold thing to do, and it is rarely only about the job. This guide is here to make the practical parts easier: where people live, what the work is like, how you would get around, and what an ordinary week might actually feel like.

It is written by people who arrange these moves for a living, which means two things. We know the questions that arrive at two in the morning. And we would rather tell you the awkward parts now than have you find them in month three.

Nothing in here is a pitch. If Nelson Tasman turns out to be the wrong answer for you, this guide should help you work that out just as quickly – and that is a good outcome, not a failed one.

Whatever you decide, you are welcome to ask us anything at all.

Sophie

FOUNDER, ETHICARE RESOURCING

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This is the short version. Every section here has a fuller chapter on our website, kept up to date — so if something looks time-sensitive, check there. We have left rents, salaries and other figures out on purpose: a number that was right when this was written would be quietly wrong by the time you read it, and a PDF cannot be corrected once it is sent. Those live on the site instead.



01

WHAKATŪ

Welcome to Nelson Tasman

Nau mai, haere mai ki Whakatū. Nelson Tasman sits at the top of the South Island, wrapped around a sheltered bay, with three national parks within reach and more sunshine than anywhere else in New Zealand. It is, by fairly common agreement, one of the loveliest places in the country to live.

~110,000

People across Nelson city and the Tasman District, from Golden Bay to St Arnaud.

~55,000

In Nelson itself, with Richmond about fifteen thousand and Motueka around eight.

~2,400 HRS

Of sunshine a year. Nelson holds the title of sunniest city in New Zealand most years, and it is the region's defining fact.

Sun, sea and three national parks

Nelson is a city of around fifty-five thousand at the head of Tasman Bay, with the Tasman District spreading west through Richmond, Māpua and Motueka to Golden Bay beyond the hill. Together they hold about a hundred and ten thousand people, and the geography is extraordinarily generous: a warm sheltered coastline on one side, mountains and beech forest on the other, and orchards and vineyards on the plains between.

Three national parks are within a comfortable drive — **Abel Tasman** with its golden beaches, **Kahurangi** with the Heaphy Track, and **Nelson Lakes** with its alpine water. No other city in New Zealand has that. Nelson also has a real arts and craft community, a proper food and craft-beer culture, and the country's oldest surviving cathedral city centre.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Nelson Tasman specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally — visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools — lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Nelson Tasman](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Cost of living](#), because the housing market is the one thing here that needs planning for.



02

THE CASE FOR NELSON TASMAN

Why Nelson Tasman

Nelson is the region people picture when they imagine moving to New Zealand. Warm, coastal, artistic, wrapped in national parks. All of that is true. The question is whether the arithmetic works for you, because it is tighter here than the postcard suggests.

MONDAY TO FRIDAY

Ten to twenty minutes to work from most of Nelson or Richmond. No congestion worth the name, and easy parking.

AFTER WORK

The Tahunanui beach, the Māitai river swimming holes in town, or the Grampians for the view. Long light evenings for most of the year.

SATURDAY

The Nelson market — one of the country's best for craft as well as produce — then a beach or a brewery.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. A nurse, radiographer, physiotherapist or sonographer on a given step earns the same in Nelson as in Auckland or Invercargill. What changes is what the money buys.

Here it buys less than you would expect. Nelson's housing costs are high relative to local incomes — not Queenstown high, but well above what a city of fifty-five thousand would normally command, because lifestyle demand from the rest of New Zealand has been pushing prices up for thirty years. You are not paid a premium for that. You are paying for the sunshine and the beaches, the same way you would in the Bay of Plenty.

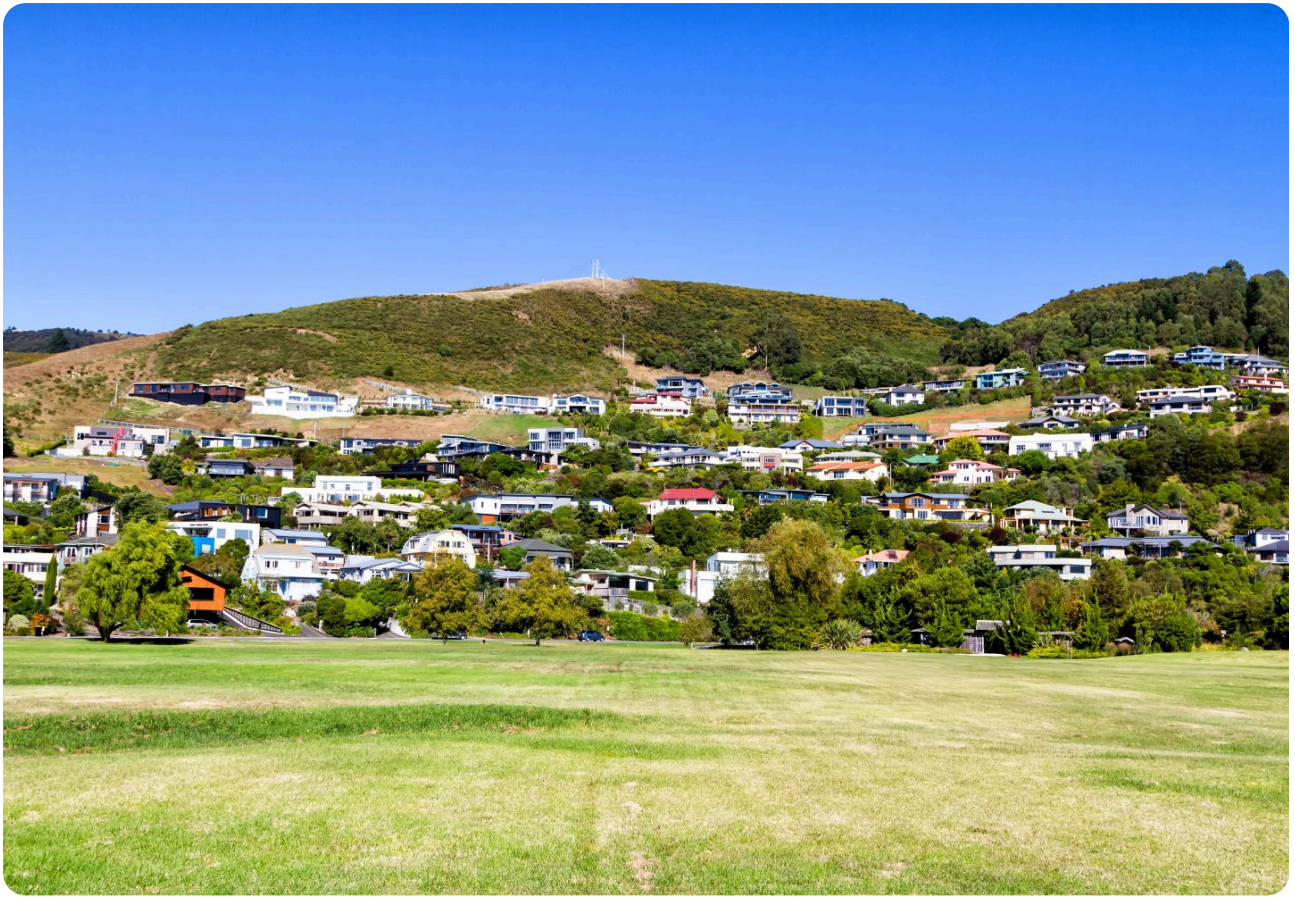
The six things people ask us

Yes. Nelson has a base hospital serving the region, plus a second hospital in Blenheim within the same district service — acute medicine and surgery, emergency, maternity, paediatrics, imaging and a broad outpatient programme. It is not a tertiary centre; the most complex work goes to Christchurch or Wellington. [Healthcare here](#) is specific about what stays and what travels.

Comfortably, renting. Buying in central Nelson or the coastal suburbs on a single clinical salary is hard, and we would not pretend otherwise. Richmond, Wakefield and Motueka are where the numbers work, and they are good places rather than compromises.

When we'd steer you elsewhere

Nelson suits clinicians who've decided the weekends are non-negotiable — three national parks within two hours isn't a brochure line, it's the local routine. Go in with housing eyes open and it's one of the easiest places in the country to be content.



03

2,400 HOURS OF SUN

Nelson Tasman at a glance

Nelson sits in a rain shadow at the head of a sheltered bay, with mountains taking the weather before it arrives. That single fact explains the sunshine, the orchards, the vineyards and why so many people want to live here.

NELSON → RICHMOND

20 minutes across the plain. The region's most-driven route.

NELSON → MĀPUA

30 minutes, to the inlet and the wharf.

NELSON → MOTUEKA

45 minutes west through the orchards.

The shape of the region

Nelson city curls around the eastern end of Tasman Bay, hemmed in by hills, with Tahunanui beach and the Boulder Bank on its seaward side. Twenty minutes south-west, **Richmond** sits on the flat Waimea plain — the region's growth area and, for many, its practical centre.

From Richmond the Tasman District runs west: Māpua on its inlet, Motueka among the orchards, and Kaiteriteri's golden sand at the edge of **Abel Tasman National Park**. Beyond that the Tākaka Hill climbs over into **Golden Bay** — Mohua — a separate world with its own famously independent community.

The four seasons

Indicative daytime highs on the coast. Inland on the Waimea plain and towards Nelson Lakes, winter frosts are routine and summer days are hotter.

The sunshine is the best in New Zealand. Around 2,400 hours a year — Nelson takes the national title most years. The ranges to the west and south strip the prevailing weather of its rain before it reaches the bay, which is why this corner is so consistently bright.

Words you'll hear

A sheltered, sunlit bay with three national parks and the best sunshine hours in the country. Mild on the coast, frosty inland, dry in summer. The climate is why everyone wants to be here — which is also why the housing costs what it does. [Where clinicians live](#) is next.

Healthcare in Nelson Tasman

Nelson Tasman offers a base hospital in a small, extremely liveable city, serving a district that stretches from Golden Bay to the Marlborough Sounds. For most professions that means real breadth without living somewhere remote.

REAL BREADTH

A base hospital with no competing centre nearby means a wide caseload and more decisions carried by you. Good for clinicians who want to be capable generalists.

A GENUINELY RURAL REACH

Golden Bay sits behind a hill road that closes in bad weather, and Murchison is well inland. Access, isolation and retrieval are live considerations.

TWO-SITE DISTRICT

Nelson and Blenheim operate as one service across a mountain range. Some roles involve travel between them — ask early, because it affects where you live.

The shape of the service

Public hospital and specialist services across the top of the South Island are delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora as a single Nelson Marlborough district. There are two hospital sites: the base hospital in **Nelson**, carrying acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics, imaging and outpatient services; and a smaller hospital in **Blenheim**, an hour and forty-five minutes east over the hills, serving Marlborough.

Around them: community and district services across Nelson, Richmond and the Tasman District, primary care, iwi and Māori health providers, aged residential care, and rural services reaching into Golden Bay and Murchison. Complex and highly specialised work is referred to Christchurch, five to six hours by road or a short flight, and to Wellington for some services.

Working with te ao Māori

Te Tau Ihu is the rohe of eight iwi — a more layered landscape than most New Zealand regions, reflecting the history of migration and settlement at the top of the South Island. Iwi and Māori health providers are active partners in care delivery here, particularly in the rural districts and Golden Bay.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau involved in decisions. You are not expected to arrive fluent — you are expected to try. The national chapter [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured — ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system — lives in [How the health system works](#).



05

TWELVE PLACES COMPARED

Where clinicians live

The decision here is mostly financial. Nelson city is lovely and expensive; Richmond and the Tasman District are lovely and considerably less so. Because commutes are short in both directions, going further out costs you very little time.

**THE WOOD & CENTRAL
NELSON**

Character villas and cottages walking distance from the cathedral, the shops and the Māitai. Desirable, walkable, and priced for it. Ten minutes to the hospital.

**BRITANNIA HEIGHTS & PORT
HILLS**

Elevated streets with views over the bay. Some of the region's best addresses, and the prices to match.

TAHUNANUI

The beach suburb — the city's main swimming beach, campground and a mixed, friendly community. Better value than the hills, and popular for it.

Further out

Most clinicians we move here rent for six to twelve months before buying, which is the right call in a market this tight. How renting works — the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards — is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#).



06

THE ONE THING TO PLAN FOR

Cost of living

Nelson is one of two regions in this collection where the housing market asks something real of you. It is not Queenstown — but it costs more than a city of fifty-five thousand people should, and for exactly the reason you would guess.

BRITANNIA HEIGHTS & THE PORT HILLS

**The premium end —
views over the bay, and
the region's highest
prices. Limited stock.**

THE WOOD & CENTRAL NELSON

**Character villas,
walkable to everything.
Charming, sought-after,
and often cold — check
the insulation.**

TAHUNANUI & ATAWHAI

**Coastal but better value
than the hills. Tahunanui
in particular offers
beach living at a sensible
price.**

Why there are no prices on this page

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Nelson Tasman against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

Why it costs what it does

Thirty years of people from the rest of New Zealand deciding they would like to live in the sunniest, most beautiful small city in the country. Retirees selling in Auckland and Wellington, lifestyle buyers, and a finite amount of flat land between the hills and the sea. Local wages have not kept pace, so Nelson regularly appears among the less affordable places in New Zealand relative to income.

Clinical pay is national. You arrive on the same salary you would earn in Palmerston North or Invercargill, into a materially more expensive market. There is no regional loading to close the gap. What you are buying is 2,400 hours of sunshine and three national parks, and that is a real thing to buy — but go in knowing the price.

Renting, by area

The same small place to live, priced by whether it has a Nelson address. This is the one decision in this chapter that moves real money.

Monthly rent for a room or small one-bedroom, expressed against Richmond as the baseline. Over a year the gap is worth more than two months' rent. Richmond is twenty to twenty-five minutes from Nelson Hospital and Wakefield thirty to forty-five — which is why the area you choose is the first thing we raise with clinicians moving here.

Getting around

Inside the region, getting around is easy: short flat commutes and one of the country's better cycle networks. Getting out of the region is the honest cost of living at the top of the South Island.

THE EBUS NETWORK

Electric buses linking Nelson, Stoke, Richmond, Wakefield and Motueka. Cheap, pleasant and useful on the main corridors.

ITS LIMITS

Modest frequency, thin in the evenings, and it will not cover a clinical roster or a rural outreach role.

DO YOU NEED A CAR?

Yes — though possibly only one per household if you cycle and live centrally. The national parks and the beaches all assume a vehicle.

The commute

Ten to twenty minutes to work from most of Nelson, Stoke or Richmond. There is mild congestion on the Nelson–Richmond corridor at either end of the day, and that is the whole traffic story. Parking at the hospital and in town is straightforward.

Because the region is compact along the coast and flat on the plain, going further out for cheaper housing costs remarkably little time. Richmond is twenty minutes, Wakefield thirty, Motueka forty-five. That is why the housing decision here is more about money than commute.

Cycling

The **Great Taste Trail** is one of New Zealand's Great Rides and unusually practical — a mostly flat, sealed network linking Nelson, Richmond, Māpua, Motueka and Wakefield, along coast, estuary and orchard. It connects real places, so it works for commuting as well as weekends.

Combined with the sunshine, that makes Nelson a good cycling city year-round. A number of clinicians here commute by bike or e-bike, and the trail is a large part of why.

Distances worth knowing

Times on a good run. Check the Tākaka Hill and the Rai Valley road in bad weather.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).



08

MAKERS, HOPS AND ORCHARDS

Food, craft & the everyday

Nelson has two things a city of this size has no right to: a serious craft-beer culture and a genuine community of working artists. Both come from the same place — decades of people choosing to live here and then having to make something.

CENTRAL NELSON

A good, compact scene — Hardy and Trafalgar Streets for restaurants, wine bars and cafés, plus the breweries. Better than the city's size suggests.

MĀPUA & MOTUEKA

The wharf at Māpua for a long lunch, Motueka for good cafés and a genuine alternative streak. Both worth the drive.

GROCERIES

All the main chains across Nelson and Richmond. Prices around the national average, with local produce noticeably cheaper.

Hops, beer and wine

Almost all of New Zealand's hops are grown on the Waimea plain, and that is not an incidental fact — it is why Nelson became the centre of the country's craft-brewing industry. There are more breweries per head here than anywhere else in New Zealand, and a genuine local culture around them rather than a tourist one.

The region also grows excellent aromatic wine — sauvignon blanc, chardonnay, pinot noir and particularly good rieslings and pinot gris — with cellar doors through the Moutere hills and out towards Māpua. Marlborough is next door if you want more.

What grows here

Apples and pears from the Motueka and Moutere districts, berries, kiwifruit, hops, and olives. Roadside stalls and orchard gates through the season, sold cheaply because there is so much of it.

The **Nelson Market** on Saturday morning is the region's fixture and unusual in the country for being as strong on craft as on produce — pottery, jewellery, glass, wood and textiles alongside the vegetables. The Motueka and Māpua markets are smaller and worth the trip.

The arts community

This is a real thing rather than a brochure line. Nelson has been a centre for potters, glass artists, jewellers, painters and weavers since the 1960s, drawn by cheap land and good light, and the community has compounded ever since. There are working studios throughout the region, a strong gallery scene, the Suter art gallery in the city, and the World of WearableArt originated here.

Practically, for a clinician: it means a small city with a genuine cultural life, evening classes and studios you can actually join, and a social world that is not only sport. That is rarer in New Zealand's small cities than you might expect.



09

WEEKENDS HERE

Three national parks

No other city in New Zealand has three national parks within reach. Golden beaches an hour north, alpine lakes ninety minutes south, and one of the great wilderness tracks starting over the hill. This is the chapter that needs no argument.

**KAHURANGI NATIONAL
PARK**

Vast, wild and far less visited — beech forest, marble karst, alpine tops and the second-largest park in the country.

THE HEAPHY TRACK

A Great Walk from Golden Bay through to the West Coast. Four to six days, and mountain-bikeable in winter.

WHARARIKI BEACH

At the very top of the South Island past Tākaka — wind-carved arches, dunes and seal pups. Spectacular.

Abel Tasman

The country's smallest national park and possibly its most loved: granite headlands, golden sand, clear water and a coast track running the length of it. The southern gateway at **Kaiteriteri** is about an hour from Nelson, which means a beach that people fly across the world for is your ordinary Sunday.

The **Coast Track** is a three-to-five day Great Walk, but the clever local move is the water taxi — boat out, walk a section, boat back. Kayaking here is exceptional, and the seals and birdlife are close. Book ahead in summer; go in autumn if you can.

Useful links

The region's official visitor site: the parks, the trails, the makers and what's on.

OUTDOORS

Department of Conservation ↗

Great Walks, huts, bookings and alerts for all three national parks.

COUNCIL

Nelson City Council ↗

Local services, libraries, pools, parks and community programmes.

COUNCIL

Tasman District Council ↗

Richmond, Motueka, Golden Bay and the rural districts.

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Nelson Tasman. Everything national — visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori — lives in [Moving to New Zealand](#). When you'd like to talk it through, [we're here](#), with no pressure and no pipeline.

Where to go next

You do not need a moving date, a decision or a CV to talk to us. If Nelson Tasman is on your list, tell us what you do and what you are weighing up, and we will be straight with you about whether we can help.

Everything on our website is free to read whether or not you ever work with us.

The full Nelson Tasman guide – ethicareresourcing.com/destinations/nelson-tasman-new-zealand

Registration pathway checker – ethicareresourcing.com/pathway-checker

What reaches your bank account – ethicareresourcing.com/take-home-pay

What the move itself costs – ethicareresourcing.com/cost-calculator

Talk to us – hello@ethicareresourcing.com
